Supplementary Appendix 1. Search strategy

Search Categories (4): (1) physical therapist, (2) communication, (3) qualitative research, and (4) chronic pain

Databases (7): MEDLINE (PubMed), CINAHL, Scopus, PsycINFO, ScienceDirect, SPORTDiscus, Linguistics and Language Behavior Abstracts (LLBA) (ProQuest)

Databases removed due to 0 hits (3): ComDisDome, PsycARTICLES, Communication and Mass Media Complete

Database	**Search Strategy:**
MEDLINE (PubMed)	**Search 1**
	MeSH Terms Physical therapists/ OR (physiotherapist* or "physical therapist*")
	AND
	MeSH Terms Communication OR (health communication OR "communication, nonverbal" OR "social interaction" OR "professional patient relations" OR "therapeutic alliance" [Other Term]) OR "misinformation" OR "information seeking behavior" OR "negotiating" OR "narrative medicine" OR "language" OR "verbal behavior" OR "facial expression" OR "laughter" OR "kinesics" OR "touch" OR "therapeutic touch" OR "speech communication barrier" OR "disclosure" OR "health literacy" OR "truth disclosure" OR "therapeutic alliance"
	AND
	MeSH Terms Qualitative research OR "grounded theory" OR "interview" OR "focus group" OR "ethnography" OR "conversation analysis" [Other Term]) OR "mixed method"
	AND
	MeSH Terms Chronic pain

	Search 2
	MeSH Terms Physical therapists/ OR (physiotherapist* or "physical therapist*")
	AND
	MeSH Terms Communication OR (health communication OR "communication, nonverbal" OR "social interaction" OR "professional patient relations" OR "therapeutic alliance" [Other Term]) OR "misinformation" OR "information seeking behavior" OR "negotiating" OR "narrative medicine" OR "language" OR "verbal behavior" OR "facial expression" OR "laughter" OR "kinesics" OR "touch" OR "therapeutic touch" OR "speech communication barrier" OR "disclosure" OR "health literacy" OR "truth disclosure" OR "therapeutic alliance"
	AND
	MeSH Terms Qualitative research OR "grounded theory" OR "interview" OR "focus group" OR "ethnography" OR "conversation analysis" [Other Term]) OR "mixed method"
	AND
	MeSH Terms Chronic pain OR "persistent pain" OR "long term pain"
CINAHL Plus with Full Text	**Search 1**
	Advanced Search Parameters: 1. Search mode → Boolean/Phrase 2. Publication type → "journal article" 3. Language → "English"
	Terms Physical therapist OR "physiotherapist"
	AND
	Terms Communication OR "health communication" OR "communication, nonverbal" OR social "interaction" OR "professional patient relations" OR "therapeutic alliance" OR "misinformation" OR "information seeking behavior" OR "negotiating" OR "narrative medicine" OR "language" OR "verbal behavior" OR "facial expression" OR "laughter" OR "kinesics" OR "touch" OR "therapeutic touch" OR "speech" OR "communication barrier" OR "disclosure" OR

	"health literacy" OR "truth disclosure" OR "therapeutic alliance"
	AND
	Terms Qualitative research OR "grounded theory" OR "interview" OR "focus group" OR "ethnography" OR "conversation analysis" OR "mixed method"
	AND
	Terms Chronic pain OR "persistent pain" OR "long term pain"
Scopus (Elsevier)	**Search 1**
	Keywords Physical therapist OR "physiotherapist"
	AND
	Keywords Communication OR "health communication" OR "communication, nonverbal" OR "social interaction" OR "professional patient relations" OR "therapeutic alliance" OR "misinformation" OR "information seeking behavior" OR "negotiating" OR "narrative medicine" OR "language" OR "verbal behavior" OR "facial expression" OR "laughter" OR "kinesics" OR "touch" OR "therapeutic touch" OR "speech" OR "communication barrier" OR "disclosure" OR "health literacy" OR "truth disclosure" OR "therapeutic alliance"
	AND
	Keywords Qualitative research OR "grounded theory" OR "interview" OR "focus group" OR "ethnography" OR "conversation analysis" OR "mixed method"
	AND
	Keywords Chronic pain OR "long term pain" OR "persistent pain"
PsycINFO (EBSCO host)	**Search 1**
	Keywords Physical therapist OR "physiotherapist"
	AND
	Keywords Communication OR "health communication" OR "communication, nonverbal" OR "social interaction" OR "professional patient relations" OR "therapeutic alliance" OR "misinformation" OR "information seeking behavior" OR "negotiating" OR "narrative medicine" OR "language" OR "verbal behavior" OR "facial expression" OR "laughter" OR "kinesics" OR

	"touch" OR "therapeutic touch" OR "speech" OR "communication barrier" OR "disclosure" OR "health literacy" OR "truth disclosure" OR "therapeutic alliance"
	AND
	Keywords Qualitative research OR "grounded theory" OR "interview" OR "focus group" OR "ethnography" OR "conversation analysis" OR "mixed method"
	AND
	Keywords Chronic pain OR "long term pain" OR "persistent pain"
ScienceDirect (Elsevier)*	**Search 1**
	Advanced Search Parameters: 4. Publication type → "Research articles"
	Keywords Physical therapist OR "physiotherapist"
	AND
	Keywords Communication
	AND
	Keywords Qualitative research OR "mixed methods" OR "grounded theory"
	AND
	Keywords Chronic pain OR "long term pain" OR "persistent pain"
SPORTDiscus (EBSCO host)	**Search 1**
	Keywords Physical therapist OR "physiotherapist"
	AND
	Keywords Communication OR "health communication" OR "communication, nonverbal" OR "social interaction" OR "professional patient relations" OR "therapeutic alliance" OR "misinformation" OR "information seeking behavior" OR "negotiating" OR "narrative medicine" OR "language" OR "verbal behavior" OR "facial expression" OR "laughter" OR "kinesics" OR "touch" OR "therapeutic touch" OR "speech" OR "communication barrier" OR "disclosure" OR "health literacy" OR "truth disclosure" OR "therapeutic alliance"
	AND
	Keywords

	Qualitative research OR "grounded theory" OR "interview" OR "focus group" OR "ethnography" OR "conversation analysis" OR "mixed method"
	AND
	Keywords Chronic pain OR "long term pain" OR "persistent pain"
Linguistics and Language Behavior Abstracts (LLBA) (ProQuest)	**Search 1**
	Advanced Search Parameters: 5. Limit to → "Peer Reviewed" 6. Source type → "Scholarly journals" 7. Language → "English"
	Keywords Physical therapist OR "physiotherapist"
	AND
	Keywords Communication OR "health communication" OR "communication, nonverbal" OR "social interaction" OR "professional patient relations" OR "therapeutic alliance" OR "misinformation" OR "information seeking behavior" OR "negotiating" OR "narrative medicine" OR "language" OR "verbal behavior" OR "facial expression" OR "laughter" OR "kinesics" OR "touch" OR "therapeutic touch" OR "speech" OR "communication barrier" OR "disclosure" OR "health literacy" OR "truth disclosure" OR "therapeutic alliance"
	AND
	Keywords Qualitative research OR "grounded theory" OR "interview" OR "focus group" OR "ethnography" OR "conversation analysis" OR "mixed method"
	AND
	Keywords Chronic pain OR "long term pain" OR "persistent pain"

*Search parameters limited by database functions. Database did not allow more than 8 Boolean connectors, therefore search terms were prioritized.

Supplementary Appendix 2. Sensitivity analysis for contribution of included studies to each communication theme

Communication Theme	Afrell & Rudebeck[43]	Askew et al.[33]	Cooper et al.[44]	Cowell et al.[45]	Del Baño-Aledo et al.[46]	Gard et al.[41]	Øien et al.[52]	Opsommer & Schoeb[48]	Pincus et al.[49]	Serpanou et al.[50]	Synnott et al.[51]	*number* of studies
Disclosure-facilitating	■							■		■	■	4
Rapport-building		■	■		■	■			■	■		6
Empathic		■		■	■							3
Collaborative			■	■			■			■		4
Professional accountability						■			■			2
Informative		■	■	■	■						■	5
Agenda-setting								■				1
Meta-communication	■						■					2